

The Morin Non-Use Task (M-NUT) :

Non-Instrumental Play as an Entry Key to Ease

A protocol designed to probe an evaluation-suppressed positive affect threshold, By
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V2.0

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Evaluation kills entry, not the state: a threshold model of ease.

Many adults report a qualitative discontinuity between childhood affect and adult affect. This protocol tests whether evaluative load modulates access to a distinct regime consistent with those reports. In many adults, joy seems to be a structure blocked by evaluation, micro-optimization, and constant self-checking.

But the moment one tries to “stop evaluating”, that attempt becomes another evaluation. So one can’t access joy by willpower or insight alone.

A task must break the loop indirectly, long enough for the system to flip.

Within this framework, any method claiming to access the ease regime while preserving continuous evaluation would contradict the proposed mechanism.. Hence, this simple protocol is aimed at disrupting evaluative optimization (veto) in the subject. To know exactly what the ease regime feels like once unlocked, jump to page 10.

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Operational definition (M-NUT effect).

The M-NUT effect is defined as a **threshold-like, discontinuous transition** into a distinct high positive affect regime, occurring under **monitoring-disruption constraints**. A positive hit requires: (i) **repeated clean failures** prior to first access, (ii) **abrupt onset** (discontinuity rather than gradual improvement), (iii) **qualitative distinctness** from ordinary good mood/arousal, (iv) **cross-context generalization** beyond the task within 24 hours, and (v) at least one instance of **persistence beyond acute stimulation** when caffeine/alcohol are used. This definition is intended to prevent post-hoc relabeling of ordinary enjoyment as a “threshold transition”.

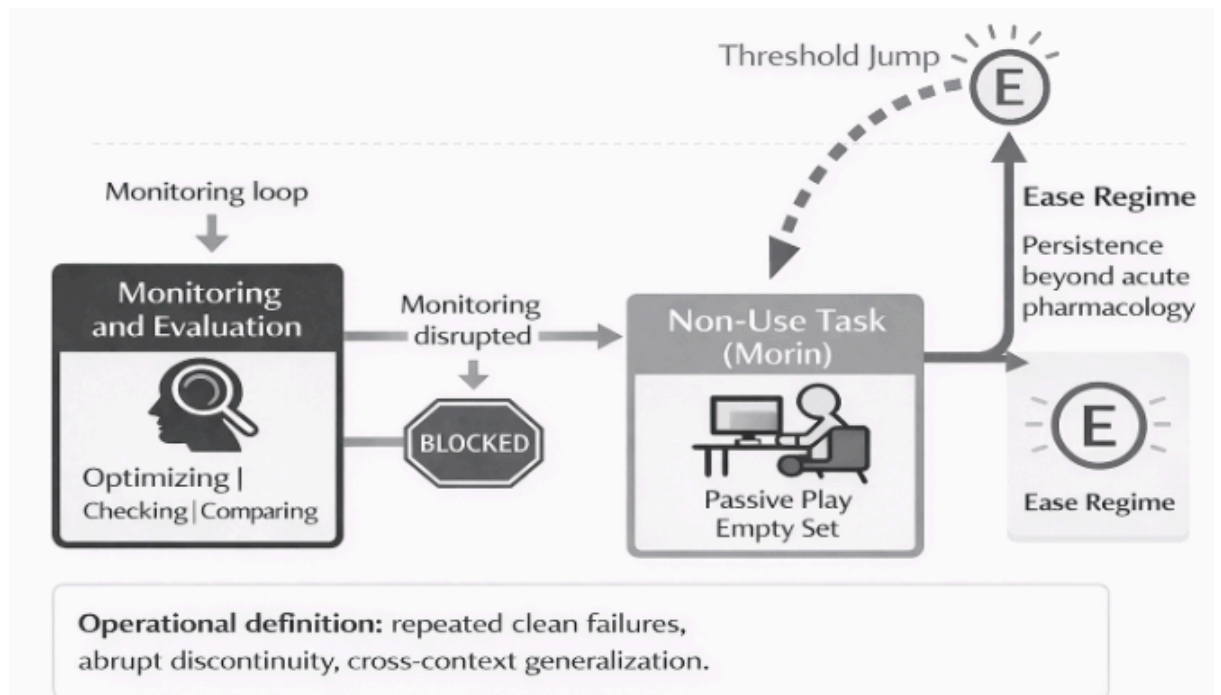


Figure 1. Canonical structure of the M-NUT effect (Morin, 2026). The monitoring and evaluation loop blocks entry into the ease regime by increasing performance checking and micro-optimization. The Morin Non-Use Task (M-NUT) disrupts monitoring long enough to permit a threshold-like transition. The predicted signature is repeated clean failures followed by an abrupt discontinuity, cross-context generalization, and persistence beyond acute stimulation.

In this framework, joy is not merely a complex system property, but a thresholded dynamic regime whose access depends on monitoring constraints and produces a discontinuous, falsifiable transition signature.

Aim

Aim.

To test whether evaluative monitoring suppresses entry into a distinct high positive affect regime (“ease”), producing a threshold-like access pattern (repeated failures followed by abrupt discontinuity).

Core manipulation.

Reduction of monitoring, performance checking, and micro-optimization during a standardized low-stakes task.

Duration.

3 days (after 2–4 days of brief concept acquisition exercises).

Primary outcome (minimal log).

Daily access (0/1), latency (min), duration (min), intensity (0–10), context.

Canonical signature (M-NUT effect).

Repeated clean failures prior to first access, abrupt discontinuity, cross-context generalization within 24h, and persistence beyond acute stimulation (when caffeine/alcohol are used).

Key falsifiers (non-negotiable).

- (1) Monitoring does not reduce success probability,
- (2) caffeine alone reliably reproduces the effect without constraints,
- (3) the effect correlates primarily with winning/performance,
- (4) reports are indistinguishable from ordinary arousal or mood improvement.

Operational threshold marker (optional).

For lightweight logs, a transition can be flagged when a transition **access = 1 and intensity ≥ 7** occurs. This is intended as a standardized discontinuity marker, not as a full measurement model.

Warm-up (Concept Acquisition, 2 to 4 days)

Before the UT99 protocol, spend 2 to 4 days learning what “suspending optimization” means in practice. If done right and not too much, it will help relax the monitor. If done too much, it will strengthen-it up instead. This is U shaped.

So this is not training. The goal is not to improve because repetition can backfire.

The goal is to recognize :

1. **Anticipatory commitment** (deciding too early)
2. **Premature closure** (the urge to finish / resolve)
3. **Monitoring / performance-checking**
The reflex to ask “Am I doing it right?” or “Is it working?”
4. **Justification / narrativization**
The reflex to generate a reason, meaning, or purpose (“why did I do that?”).
5. **Correction / micro-adjustment**
The reflex to “fix it just a little” after an action is completed.
6. **Salience veto / down-regulation of specialness**
The reflex to cancel emerging specialness through explanation, comparison, or reproduction attempts.
7. **Expectancy resolution**
The reflex that if an expectancy state is created (“something important is about to happen”), it must be resolved by an outcome.

FPS (first-person shooter) protocol (3 days)

Once the concept is clear, proceed to the FPS protocol. Unreal tournament 99 will give a combination of suspended optimization, prediction errors and distraction. Low dose coffee for additional stimulation will help unlock the brain regime.

UT99 is used as a standardized “empty” environment that makes it easier to disrupt evaluation long enough for the system to flip. Low-dose coffee can be used as a threshold helper on Day 3, as described below.

First,

The Warm-up

Any performance-check thought (“Am I doing this correctly?”) is treated as a stop signal. End the trial immediately. If you think ‘I’ll optimize just a little’, the session has already collapsed. Am I doing it right?” “Is it working?”, “Just a little optimization...” = pause the warm-up. Therefore, all warm-up exercises are designed to be short. Longer exposure increases optimization, habituation, and self-monitoring.

General rules : Avoid tracking time. Avoid imaginary discussions in your head, or very low dose coffee (a sup), it may even help.

“Optional modulators (exploratory)” : low-dose anxiolytic modulation (e.g., a single sip of low-alcohol beverage), where ethically permitted.”

The exercises :

On youtube, deliberately choose a sub-optimal video. Do not optimize the selection.

Start a music video. As soon as you notice it becoming enjoyable, close it immediately.

Pick a music video. Jump to a random timestamp (no scanning). Watch for ~40 seconds. Then return to normal playback. If it’s not enjoyable, it’s good.

Open a book at random. Read one paragraph. Then jump to another random page and read one paragraph. Do not try to reconstruct the story, and choose a sub-optimal book (not the most interesting one).

Turn the TV on. Select the first acceptable channel. Do not browse for a better one. Do not increase image quality, sound quality, or subtitles. Keep it slightly sub-optimal.

Form a simple mental image (e.g., a red apple). Do not refresh it. Do not force it to stay. Simply notice when it fades. Do not try to extend it. Do not restart it immediately. Only one trial.

Make a tiny, low-stakes choice (posture, light, a song). Commit immediately. Do not justify it. Do not check whether it was the right choice. If you notice yourself comparing alternatives, stop and choose the first acceptable option.

During the day, if something spontaneously feels special (a music moment, an image, a memory, a concept), allow it to be special for a few seconds. Do not intensify it. Do not explain it. Do not try to reproduce it. Do not search for special moments. (Adults often veto specialness automatically. This step is just: let it be special for few seconds, without explaining. The system can re-learn that specialness still exists)

Look at an object, a thought, or a sound. Internally label it as ‘almost interesting’. Not interesting. Not neutral. Almost.

Perform a deliberately precise gesture with no utility (e.g., place an object perfectly parallel to an imaginary line). After it is done, make zero corrections, even if it is not perfect. Do not even evaluate quality.

Choose an ordinary object. Decide: For the next 30 seconds, this is the most important object in the room. Do not stare at it, just let it exist as special (Trains the pure capacity to mark something as salient, independent of pleasure).

In a noisy environment, pick one sound as primary (a voice, a hum, a bird, a distant car). Do not amplify it, do not track it actively. Simply let your brain treat it as central for 10 to 20 seconds.

Let mental imagery run without checking. Accept incomplete, unstable, or drifting scenes. Treating image as “allowed” rather than “accurate”.

While walking (or speaking to yourself), stop abruptly for no reason. Wait 1 to 3 seconds. Start again without analyzing why you stopped.

Notice the moment a tiny opinion is about to form (good/bad, cringe/cool, interesting/boring). Do not complete it. Let it abort.

Briefly generate a feeling of recognition or approval, as if you were acknowledging someone, but with no recipient. Hold it for a few seconds. Then drop it. No imagining a person.

Briefly generate the internal sense ‘something important is about to happen’. Hold it for few seconds. Then allow nothing to happen. Drop it.

Form a simple question in your mind. Interrupt it before the question mark. Do not complete it. Do not answer it. Exemple : “What if I...” (stop)

Next,

With the help of a game

M-NUT can be implemented using any low-stakes environment satisfying constraints C1-C5.

- C1: no performance feedback
- C2: no optimization goal

- C3: low salience
- C4: distraction-compatible
- C5: monitoring stop rule. Any explicit performance-check or feeling-check operation terminates the session (or marks it as invalid).

UT99 is used only for standardization and because it minimizes modern performance pressure.

Install Unreal tournament 1999

https://ut99.org/viewtopic.php?f=1&t=16618&sid=d07a79bd3c656e00boce30e19cf_a0967

Play the tutorial so you understand the basics. Once you understand the game, remove HUD in the visual option. You will also change the resolution to a lower-than optimal one, depending on your equipment. Let's say your monitor is 1400*900, then use 1024*768.

If fatigue is high, postpone the attempt (fatigue may increase monitoring).

If you are ready, it's time to prepare some coffee (At this time, the *exact* most effective dose or maximal effective dose is not clear).

“Optional modulators (exploratory)”
Anxiolytic modulation.

And for a while, stop looking at the time. Don't watch the clock.
Don't simulate discussions in your head. Don't clench your jaw.

The Non-use task. Total time : ~5 minutes :

Start the game with that blank mind. You can say to yourself “there is nothing to optimize here”, to prevent seeking optimization moves. Now, deathmatch mode, easy-to-normal level.

If a thought appears, either ignore or think “later”, so you don't dwell on them.
In the game, don't try to win.

After 1-2 minutes of passive play, participants perform a brief period of random, arrhythmic motor interference (e.g., shoulder movement), without counting or optimizing.

Then continue to play, and then take the additional substance, a sip. Not more.

Continue playing a bit.

Switch to a short video stimulus under reduced sensory fidelity (e.g., low resolution, 360p), to minimize salience optimization and 'best-quality seeking'.

Next day, do the same. Third day, replace the *eventual use* of alcohol with a sip of coffee.

“Alcohol is not a core component of M-NUT and should be omitted in institutional studies if not approved.”

The goal of the task is to stop you asking “what do I feel/is it working/am i doing good?”. Alcohol, is supposed to help relax the monitor and coffee helps crossing a threshold that may induce a high positive affect, in some cases it will be stable. However, the more you do it, the less likely it will work. The idea is to suspend optimization and evaluation behaviors.

Optional high-constraint condition (exploratory)

Participants are encouraged to avoid high-load obligations and social evaluation on the test day. For imaginary social life (eg. arguments) use thought suppression (Wegner, 1987) . No news watching, scrolling, comments or metrics reading from social media. You can watch youtube, but only on 360p.

In the FPS protocol, add “switch weapons for no reasons”, and “hesitate briefly between two path (2-5 secondes)”.

Wegner, D. M., Schneider, D. J., Carter, S. R., & White, T. L. (1987). Paradoxical effects of thought suppression. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 53(1), 5–13.
<https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.53.1.5>

Note

Although early observations suggested that a single exposure may be sufficient, subsequent informal replications indicate that multiple attempts across days can be required before the first successful transition. This pattern is treated as an entry

barrier rather than a graded training effect. The protocol separates task performance improvements from the hypothesized state transition: a learning account predicts gradual change tracking increasing mastery, whereas the present account predicts repeated failures followed by an abrupt, disproportionate shift in global affect. Low-dose caffeine and low-dose alcohol are treated as optional contextual modulators, respectively targeting vigilance and monitoring relaxation, but they are not considered sufficient explanations given the reported persistence of the regime beyond acute pharmacological timescales. Persistence is assessed via a minimal daily log (access yes/no, latency, duration, intensity, context) and a weekly check-in (practice requirement, major lifestyle changes).

Appendix 1

Threshold vs Learning Model

Two competing accounts can explain changes in affect observed during structured engagement tasks.

Learning Account

Under a learning or skill-acquisition model, repeated exposure leads to graded improvement. Affective intensity should increase gradually as familiarity, fluency, or performance improves. The trajectory is expected to be monotonic and proportional

to mastery. Improvements should correlate with measurable behavioral gains, such as faster reactions, better performance, or increased control.

Predicted signature under learning:

- Progressive improvement across sessions
- Performance-affect correlation
- No sharp discontinuities
- Effect reproducible through repetition alone

Threshold Regime-Shift Account

Under the present framework, affective access is gated by evaluative monitoring and micro-optimization. The relevant variable is not skill but evaluative load. When monitoring remains active, access probability remains low. When monitoring falls below a critical threshold under constrained conditions, a discontinuous transition may occur.

The predicted pattern is not graded improvement but:

- Repeated clean failures across sessions
- Abrupt onset rather than gradual build-up
- Magnitude disproportionate to task performance
- Cross-context generalization beyond the task
- Persistence beyond acute stimulation windows

The first successful transition may occur after multiple null sessions. This delay is interpreted not as training but as evidence of an entry barrier. Under a threshold model, repeated failure followed by sudden discontinuity is expected behavior, not anomaly.

Discriminating Predictions

The two accounts make incompatible predictions.

If affect tracks mastery, repetition, or performance metrics, the learning model is supported.

If affect appears as a discontinuous jump independent of skill progression, especially after multiple prior null attempts, the threshold model is supported.

A gradual improvement curve falsifies the regime-shift hypothesis. A brittle, state-dependent discontinuity challenges simple learning or stimulation explanations.

The present protocol is designed to differentiate these models empirically rather than rhetorically.

Taken together, these clarifications preserve the central claim: the intervention appears to modulate the probability of entering a distinct affective regime characterized by abrupt onset, unusually high intensity, and persistence beyond the timescale of transient pharmacological or contextual effects, even when multiple attempts are required before the first successful transition.

Appendix 2 : Failures modes

A failure is actually informative because it suggests the task isn't a universal "joy button", it's a very specific key that only works when certain hidden prerequisites are already satisfied (low enough load, right expectancy structure, right micro-timing, etc.).

Also, a single failure can happen for reasons that have nothing to do with the core mechanism, like:

- they did it with the wrong "spirit" (too much trying / evaluation),
- they rushed it,
- they didn't follow the constraints precisely,
- they were in a high-load day (stress, sleep debt, future tasks in mind),

Most people will unknowingly "do it right" in an instrumental way. They try to succeed at the task, they try to feel something, they try to optimize. That alone can keep them in the normal adult regime.

They expected a gradual effect

If they're waiting for a slow "mood improvement", they may miss the real signature, which is more like: nothing, nothing, nothing... then a sudden shift.

A single failed attempt is exactly what you expect from something that operates as a regime shift rather than a linear effect. If the task were producing a smooth, dose-like increase in affect across everyone, failure would be suspicious. Regime transitions are thresholded, brittle, and state-dependent. Either the constraints line up and the system flips, or nothing happens at all. From that perspective, “it failed” is not noise, it’s a clean data point that says the threshold was not crossed for that individual at that moment.

One common case of failure is insufficient constraint: the person performs the task mechanically, instrumentally, or with covert goal pursuit. If they are trying to “get the effect,” monitoring their own state, checking whether something is happening, or optimizing execution, the task collapses back into ordinary control. The task only works when it is treated as structurally pointless. Many people cannot actually do that on the first try, even if they think they are.

Another failure mode is excessive background load. If the person is in a high-pressure context, socially evaluated, time-compressed, or cognitively saturated, the system may simply be unable to drop into the permissive regime. In that case the task does not fail in principle, it fails because it is competing with stronger active constraints. This is consistent with the observation that the same individual may fail one day and succeed another, without any change in the task itself.

There is also a learning and unlearning component. For some people, especially adults who have been optimizing for a long time, the first exposure to the task functions more like a probe than an intervention. It reveals how quickly they reassert control, how fast they reframe the activity as useful or evaluable. Only later attempts, sometimes after explicit reframing or after experiencing that “nothing bad happens” when the task goes nowhere, allow the drop to occur.

Importantly, failure helps distinguish mechanisms. If the effect were due to simple distraction, novelty, or generic mood elevation, most people would show at least a small positive shift. A clean zero or negative result argues against those explanations. It suggests that something specific has to be permitted rather than induced. That makes the theory stronger, not weaker.

We are describing a conditional access protocol to a state that modern adults often block. The existence of failures is exactly what one would predict if the block is real.

So the right takeaway is not “this time the task doesn’t work,” but “the task is sensitive enough that failure tells us something precise about state, context, and control.”

Predictions (what should happen if the framework is correct)

If the Ease Threshold Hypothesis is correct, the following predictions should be observed in at least a subset of subjects:

- **P1: Fragile entry, stable after crossing**
Early in the task, monitoring collapses the transition.
But once crossed, the state can become surprisingly stable for a while.
- **P2: The strongest suppressor is evaluation, not boredom**
Even with neutral content (old game, low difficulty), ease can appear if monitoring is reduced.
- **P3: Micro-optimization kills the effect**
Trying to “do the task better” reduces the probability of transition, even if motivation is high.
- **P4: The task becomes less effective with repetition**
Repeated attempts tend to increase “checking” and reduce success probability.
- **P5: Coffee acts as a threshold helper, not as the experience itself**
A small dose helps entry, but the experience (if it occurs) is not reducible to caffeine stimulation.
- **P6: The affect has a distinct qualitative signature**
If it occurs, it is not just “good mood”, but vivid, positive, childhood-like, with reduced cognitive friction.

Falsification (non-negotiable failure conditions)

The framework is weakened if the following are observed:

- **F1: No difference between monitoring vs non-monitoring**
If actively checking feelings does not reduce success probability, the core mechanism is wrong.
- **F2: The effect is fully explained by stimulation**
If the same effect is produced reliably by coffee alone, without the monitoring constraints, the protocol is not probing the claimed mechanism.
- **F3: The effect correlates mainly with winning/performance**
If ease appears only when performance is high (winning, dominance, achievement), then the “non-use / anti-optimization” claim is wrong.
- **F4: The state is not qualitatively distinct**
If reported experiences are indistinguishable from ordinary arousal, excitement, or mood improvement, the “regime shift” claim is not supported.

Operational checklist (positive M-NUT hit)

A session is counted as a positive M-NUT hit if the following criteria are met:

1. **Entry barrier signature:** at least two prior sessions on separate days yielded no access (access = 0) under correct constraints.
2. **Discontinuity:** entry is reported as a clear qualitative jump rather than graded improvement.
3. **Distinctness:** the affective state is reported as qualitatively distinct from ordinary mood improvement, excitement, or stimulation.
4. **Generalization:** the state reappears outside the task context within 24 hours, or produces a measurable global shift in daily experience not restricted to gameplay.
5. **Beyond-stimulation evidence:** if optional contextual modulators were used, at least one re-entry or persistence instance occurs outside the expected acute window.

7) Notes

- This is a **probe**, not a self-help technique.
- Do not over-repeat. Repetition itself can train monitoring.
- The goal is not to “get a reward”. The goal is to stop reward-seeking behaviors long enough to test the threshold.

“See Protocol at a glance for the optional threshold marker.”

Standardized test conditions (minimal)

To reduce interpretive ambiguity while keeping the protocol lightweight, each session should be tagged using the following minimal condition grid. This does not aim to fully control the environment, but to prevent “same protocol” claims under substantially different contexts.

Variable	Levels (record one)	Notes
Fatigue state	Low / Moderate / High	High fatigue is expected to increase monitoring and reduce entry probability. Postpone if “High”.

Social context	Alone / Others present (silent) / Social interaction	The core protocol is intended to be run alone. If not, record it explicitly.
Caffeine	None / Low-dose / Moderate+	Low-dose is treated as a threshold helper (Day 3). Avoid moderate+ due to arousal confounds.
Alcohol	None / Low-dose / Moderate+	If used, restrict to low-dose only. Moderate+ invalidates interpretation (intoxication confound).
Time of day	Morning / Afternoon / Evening / Night	Time-of-day may interact with vigilance, load, and entry fragility.
Device setup	HUD off (Y/N), resolution lowered (Y/N)	UT99 is used as a low-pressure standardized environment. HUD off + sub-optimal resolution reduces performance salience.

Optional additional tags (recommended)

These are not required, but can clarify failure modes without increasing measurement burden:

Variable	Levels
Sleep debt	None / Mild / Significant
Current load	Low / Moderate / High (work, obligations, unresolved tasks)
Clock exposure	Avoided / Checked repeatedly
Rumination	Low / Moderate / High

Limitations / Contraindications. If you do any of these exercises too often, it becomes “training to not train”, which is self-contradictory as the idea is to stop the human tendency to do training or methods. The protocol can then turn into a new performance goal, and that reintroduces evaluation, which is exactly what blocks entry. Don’t use it as a long-term life-style, as it will backfire.

Developmental considerations suggest that younger children may exhibit lower baseline evaluative load, but this remains speculative within the present framework, and it becomes locked-out in the adult. The regime, when fully unlocked, is about increased thoracic pleasure radiating to the jaw in front of absurd and aesthetic stimulus.

Appendix 3

Example of mild anxiolytic modulation (context-dependent, optional, non-essential)
: low-dose alcohol,

Exploratory phenomenological checklist (non-validated)

It's possible that you naturally have this "open" state by default, or that it is unusually easy for you to access, without any specific technique or trigger. And because this state is hard to remember from the outside, it's easy to underestimate how stable, and how uncommon, it really is.

To make this clearer, here is a short questionnaire to help you determine whether you genuinely have the open state as a baseline, or whether you only access it intermittently. Note that this is the state long after it is stabilized, not the acute transition effect.

Emotional resonance with simple / childlike signals

1. I can feel a strong emotional response to very simple songs (especially children's songs). They can trigger an automatic wave-like pleasant sensation in my chest, sometimes radiating to the jaw.
2. Religious music, chants, or hymns can trigger an automatic wave-like pleasant sensation in my chest, sometimes radiating to the jaw, even if I am not religious.

Perceptual texture shifts (visual)

3. In certain states, my visual field can look more granular (like film grain).
4. In certain states, my visual field can take on a warm or brownish tint.
5. Highly saturated or luminous visual stimuli (phosphorescent, neon-like, precious metal-like, christmas decoration-type, intensely colorful images) can trigger an automatic wave-like pleasant sensation in my chest.

Somatic wave triggers (TV / camera cuts)

6. I sometimes feel a wave-like pleasant sensation in my chest triggered by abrupt camera changes (hard cuts) while watching TV or videos.
7. This sensation feels automatic and bodily, not related to the content of the scene.
8. This effect can occur even when the scene itself is emotionally neutral.

Pleasure from perceptual impossibility (cartoons / magic)

9. Absurd cartoons or comics where characters change shape for no reason can trigger an automatic wave-like pleasant sensation in my chest or jaw, more than with simple abrupt scene changes (hard cuts).
10. Impossible scenes or images (magic, physics violations, surreal) can trigger an automatic brief wave-like pleasant sensation in my chest or jaw, even if the scene is not nostalgic or emotionally meaningful.

Sustained high positive affect (hours)

11. I can sustain a very high level of positive affect for hours (for example while watching music videos).
12. During these periods, I feel a strong pleasurable sensation in my chest.
13. Sometimes the intensity becomes almost unbearable because it is so high.
14. This state feels stable over time rather than a short peak.